DAILY TRAIL · METRICS PLAN · NOVEMBER 2026

What we measure in Daily Trail, and what we do about it

Daily Trail is a daily treasure hunt for people who love puzzles. Everyone gets the same hunt each day: a riddle, a cipher and a pattern, whose answers spell a three-letter treasure word. The product works if players come back and finish the hunt week after week.

No real player data yet.

The game is live and already records 13 kinds of player action, such as opening the game, using a hint, finishing and sharing. Those records stay on each player's device for now, so this page is the plan, not results. Every target is our starting assumption, and we reset the targets after two weeks of real data.

THE BRIEF, AND WHERE EACH PART IS ANSWERED

"Jot down the metrics to be tracked on the game to share inferences to the management and to track what works and doesn't to improve the product."

The metrics to track	The main number and six questions
What works and what doesn't, and how we improve the product	Working, not working, what we change
How inferences reach management	The Monday update
How far to trust the numbers	Read with care

THE MAIN NUMBER

Weekly active solvers

The number of different players who finish at least one hunt in a week, Monday to Sunday. A visit only shows that someone opened the page, while a finished hunt shows they got what they came for. It also tolerates a missed day, so it tracks a habit rather than a perfect streak.

Six questions we answer each week

Each question lists its metrics with a starting target, then what working and not working look like, and the change we make when it is not working.

Do players come back?

D1 retention

New players who open the game exactly 1 day after their first visit

45%

D7 retention

The same, exactly 7 days later

25%

D30 retention

The same, exactly 30 days later

12%

Solves per active player

Finished hunts per week, divided by weekly active solvers

3 or more a week

Working

- Retention at or above target, and weekly active solvers growing week on week.

Not working, and what we change

- D1 under 30%: the first play gave no reason to return.
  Show tomorrow's hunt and the streak more clearly on the result screen, then test a reminder.
- D1 healthy but D7 under 15%: the novelty wears off, or players notice the hunts repeat.
  Add new hunts first, then look at weekly goals.
- D7 healthy but D30 under 8%: regular players run out of reasons to stay.
  Build longer-term goals, such as crews or a monthly story map.

Do they finish?

Start rate

Players who press Start, out of players who open the game and have not finished today

80%

Finish rate

Players who finish, out of players who press Start that day

75%

Stage drop-off

Players who see a stage but do not solve it, for the riddle, cipher and pattern separately

Under 10% a stage

Working

- Most players who open the game start it, and no single stage loses many of them.

Not working, and what we change

- Start rate under 60%: the intro does not make players want to begin.
  Shorten the intro and show the first puzzle sooner.
- Finish rate under 60%, with one stage causing most of the drop-off: that stage is the blocker.
  Fix that stage type before writing more content.
- The cipher loses the most players: its rules are too hard to follow.
  Simplify the "How this works" panel and strengthen the first hint.

Are the puzzles right?

Clean solve rate

Stage solves with no hint, by puzzle and stage

40% to 70%

Answer shown rate

Stage solves where the last hint showed the answer

Under 10%

Wrong answers per stage

Wrong answers divided by players who saw the stage

Under 2

Median solve time

The middle time for each stage and for the whole hunt

Hunt in 2 to 6 min

Working

- Hard enough that hints get used, easy enough that few players need the answer shown, and short enough for a daily habit.

Not working, and what we change

- Clean solve rate above 85% on a stage: too easy for this audience.
  Make that kind of puzzle harder.
- Answer shown above 20% on a stage: too hard or unfair.
  Rewrite the puzzle or its hints, and retire it if that fails.
- Many wrong answers but few hints: we may be rejecting fair answers, or players may not see the hints.
  Review accepted answers and make the hint button easier to see.
- Finish rate rises while D7 falls: the hunts may have become too easy to feel rewarding.
  Roll back the easier content and check the difficulty mix.

Does the streak build a habit?

Streak of 3 or more

Weekly active solvers holding a streak of at least 3 days

40%

Freeze return rate

Players who finish a hunt within 2 days after the weekly freeze covered a missed day

60%

Return after a broken streak

Players who finish a hunt on the day their streak resets, or the day after

40%

Working

- Players saved by a freeze come back much more often than players whose streak breaks.

Not working, and what we change

- Freezes make no visible difference: the freeze is not worth its complexity.
  Simplify the streak rules.
- Freezes clearly help: the habit is fragile around missed days.
  Test a second freeze, or a way to earn one.

Do players spread it?

Share rate

Players who use Share or Copy on their result, out of players who finish that day. The result card is spoiler free: coloured squares, time and streak.

15%

Working

- Players share their result regularly, and new players grow alongside shares.

Not working, and what we change

- Share rate under 5%: the result is not worth showing off.
  Test a new share card and a head-to-head challenge link.
- Shares are healthy but new players stay flat: shares do not bring people in.
  Track arrivals from shared links, then change the message or the link.

Do players want more than one hunt a day?

Practice rate

Players who open a practice hunt, out of players who finish that day. Practice hunts are separate from the daily hunts and never count.

Learn the normal level first

Replay rate

Players who look back at a past hunt's answers or play it again, out of players who open the game that day

Learn the normal level first

What a high rate tells us

- Practice rate above 30%: many players want more than one hunt a day.
- A high replay rate: players value their record of past hunts.

What we change

- **Add more practice hunts or a weekly bonus hunt, and check it does not lower next-day returns.**
- **Make past hunts more prominent, for example with a monthly map of finished hunts.**

How inferences reach management

Each Monday, management gets one short update with four parts:

1. Weekly active solvers, against last week.
2. D1 and D7 for the newest group of players with enough time to measure.
3. The hardest and the easiest puzzle of the week.
4. One thing we learned, one decision we made, and what we will check next week.

TEMPLATE, TO BE FILLED IN ONCE DATA EXISTS

Weekly active solvers: _____, against _____ last week.

D1: _____. D7: _____.

Hardest puzzle: _____. Easiest: _____.

Learned: _____. Decided: _____. Checking next week: _____.

Read with care

Check the group size first.
With 100 players, a measured 45% could really be anywhere from about 35% to 55%. Small differences mean little until each group has several hundred players.

A player means one browser on one device.
Someone on a second device, in a private window or after clearing browser data counts as a new player. This inflates new players and lowers retention a little.

Streak numbers miss players who leave for good.
A streak change is only recorded when a player opens the game, so read streak numbers alongside retention.

Freeze comparisons do not prove cause.
Players who keep a streak long enough to use a freeze may already be more committed. An A/B test is needed before we credit the freeze.

Each puzzle always falls on the same weekday.
There are seven daily hunts on a seven-day cycle, so a hard puzzle and a slow weekday look the same.

Hunts repeat after seven days.
Returning players may remember the answers, so we judge puzzle difficulty on first plays only.

A share is an intent, not a delivery.
Copy shows that the text was copied, not that it was posted.

The leaderboard is sample data.
Only the player's own row is real, so it tells us nothing about competition yet.

What we need before the numbers are real

Collect events in one place

Today each player's events stay on their own device, so we cannot see any numbers across players.

Fix: send events to an analytics service. This comes first, because nothing else on this page works without it.

Tag shared links

We cannot tell whether shares bring in new players.

Fix: add a tag to the link in the share text and record it on a player's first visit.

Keep wrong answers

We cannot tell typos and fair alternative answers from real mistakes.

Fix: record a privacy-safe form of wrong answers and review the most common ones.

Learn why players stop

Leaving the page also happens when someone briefly switches apps, so it only shows where a player was.

Fix: use "started but did not finish that day" as the measure, and add a one-question exit survey if needed.

Play the game: dailytrail.vercel.app

The same plan, with exact event definitions, is kept with the game's code as docs/METRICS.md and reference/events.md.